

Core Evaluation Metrics

Leah Kriel – User Story #67

User Story: As a KARA researcher, I want to identify the core child protection metrics used in the evaluation so that each state can be evaluated using consistent and relevant measures.

Possible Core Metrics

Reports: Shows how many concerns or allegations about child safety are reported to the child protection system.

Investigations: Shows how many reports move forward for investigation by the child protection system.

Substantiations: Shows how many investigated reports are determined to meet the state's standard for confirmed maltreatment.

Removals: Shows how often children are removed from their homes and placed into out-of-home care.

Foster Care Use: Shows how much the state relies on foster care or other out-of-home placements.

Child Outcomes: Looks at what happens to children after involvement with the child protection system, when comparable outcome data is available.

Why These Metrics Matter

These metrics cover different parts of the child protection process. Looking at more than one metric can give the team a broader view of how a state's system is functioning instead of relying on one number.

Comparing States

The team should only compare a metric across states when the definitions and available data are similar enough for a fair comparison. Differences in state definitions, reporting practices, or missing data should be documented.

Current Status

These are possible core metrics, not the final list. The team will refine the metrics after reviewing the datasets provided by KARA and getting feedback from the project leads.